

### **History of Columbiana County:**

Columbiana County is the eastern most county on the Ohio River in Ohio, bordering Pennsylvania to the east and West Virginia to the south. The Ohio River forms a natural border at the southern edge of the county. The area that eventually became Columbiana County was claimed by Virginia and was only a few miles south of Connecticut's Western Reserve. After the Revolutionary War in 1783, the federal government prevailed upon the states to relinquish their claims and began planning for the legal settlement and eventual political organization of the land.

Before the advent of the early settlers in the County, the Wyandots, Delaware, and Mingo Tribes of Native Americans occupied Northeastern Ohio including Columbiana County. Archeological evidence shows indigenous people here as early as 10,000 B.C.

In 1792, the first white settler, believed to be John Quinn, commonly referred to as "Hunter John Quinn", settled in St. Clair Township.

After Ohio became a State on 25 March 1803, Columbiana County was created during the first session of the Ohio General Assembly out of parts of Jefferson and Washington Counties. Governor Tiffin signed the bill creating Columbiana County on 6 April 1803. The County was named for Christopher Columbus and Queen Anna.

Since Columbiana County was organized, its land area has been reduced three times; in 1808 when Stark County was formed, in 1832 when Carroll County was formed and in 1845 when Mahoning County was formed. Today the County comprises 535 square-miles.

Most of the early settlement of the County was by people moving in from Pennsylvania. Most numerous were the Scots-Irish which settled in Madison Township and in the Highlandtown Area. Quakers, or members of the Society of Friends, began moving to the Salem area in 1803. By 1810 the county had a population of 10,788 people. The 1850 Census showed a total population of 33,621 of which 182 were African American and 33,431 were Caucasian. Scots- Irish and German were the predominant ethnic groups. Interestingly, the first county newspaper, *Der Patriot am Ohio* that began publication in 1808 was written in German. It was the first paper published west of Pittsburgh, Pennsylvania.

The County is predominately rural with two major areas of population concentration; the Salem-East Palestine corridor along the northern border of the county and the East Liverpool – Calcutta - Wellsville corridor at the southern border of the county. Together these areas contain 39% of the County's population.

Historically Columbiana County's economy was based on the extensive natural resources including coal, timber, clay, sand and gravel and prime agricultural land. The County has 150 years experience in manufacturing pottery, brick and tile from its excellent deposits of fire clay and brick shale. At one time the County was known as the "Pottery Capital of the Nation" or "America's Crockery City". The ceramics industry remains a dominant influence on the history and culture of the county. Hall China in East Liverpool and Homer Laughlin China, across the Ohio River in Newell, West Virginia, continue to be major employers for the tri-state area. Homer Laughlin is famous for its Fiesta Ware.

Coal mining was important historically. Numerous unreclaimed strip mines dot the landscape in the central and eastern portions of the County. A related industry, the production of coke for steel making, was the major industry of Leetonia, where over 200 coke ovens operated. These coke ovens still exist and can be seen in Cherry Valley Arboretum

Historically, manufacturing was also a dominant economic sector in the County. Located in the County were: The third iron furnace west of the Alleghenies, "Rebecca" built in 1808; the first paper mill in Ohio built near the mouth of Little Beaver Creek; the salt mining business developed in Salineville, and the first mill in the state to produce nails, built in an area known as Logtown in Center Township. The manufacturing economy was a subsistence economy with few surplus products and little hard cash. In recent times, local manufacturing of heavy equipment for the steel and automotive industry as well as plumbing fixtures has been impacted by globalization with the result being a significant decrease in the number of manufacturing firms in the county.

However continuing as a dominant economic force in the County is agriculture. The Ohio Department of Agriculture reports there are 1,180 farms in the County farming a total of 175,000 acres in 2004. In 2003 agricultural cash receipts from marketing of farm commodities totaled \$45,271,000 for Columbiana County. The farming community in the county is very visible and there are active Granges still.

The County has been divided both economically and culturally into what many term as "two counties". This division follows the terminus of glaciation in the county and runs west to east with Lisbon at the center. Residents living south of Lisbon tend to travel to Steubenville and Pennsylvania for employment and commercial/retail activity and residents living north of Lisbon tend to travel to Mahoning County for employment and retail/commercial activity.

The Little Beaver Creek Watershed covers over two thirds of Columbiana County's surface area. Little Beaver Creek is designated as a State Wild and Scenic and Federal Scenic River System. The watershed is noted for its diverse flora and fauna, excellent fishing as well as outstanding scenery. Hemlock gorges in the steep valleys and heavily forested riparian corridor provide excellent habitat for many songbirds and other mammals not found elsewhere in Columbiana County. Beaver Creek State Park encompassing the Watershed along with Guilford Lake State Park provide recreational and wildlife opportunities for young and old.

Two historic eras played an important role in the County's development and thus in the economic situation and cultural mindset of today. First, the Canal Era offered great economic promise to the county only to fizzle and the Civil War established the county's role in the nation's history.

In 1815, Governor Ethan Allen Brown urged the construction of canals to aid in the growth and development of Ohio. Commerce in Cleveland, Buffalo, and New York steadily increased because of the Ohio and Erie Canal but merchants in Pittsburgh and Philadelphia thought they were losing market share in the western portions of the country, primarily Ohio.

Three solutions were proposed to add the Pennsylvania merchants.

One was for the construction of the Pennsylvania & Ohio Canal from Akron on the Ohio Canal to New Castle, Pennsylvania, where it would link up with the Pennsylvania canal system.

Another proposal was for the construction of the Sandy & Beaver Canal running a parallel route about 35 miles to the south through Columbiana County. The canal would connect to the Ohio Canal near Bolivar, Ohio, follow Big Sandy Creek to New Lisbon and continue along the Middle Fork of Little Beaver Creek and meet the Ohio River at Glasgow.

A third proposal advocated the construction of the Pennsylvania & Ohio Railroad to connect the two canal systems. Although this was the most economical and logical solution there was little faith in railroads at the time.

The Ohio Legislature chartered the Sandy & Beaver Canal Company on 11 January 1828. The original plan called for the canal to be 90.5 miles long and to cost \$1,292,465.32 with 10,000 boats projected to use the canal annually. Ground was broken on 24 November 1834 and the next month the Ohio Legislature appropriated \$50,000 to assist the Sandy & Beaver Canal Company.

The canal ended up being only 73.5 miles in length. Ninety locks were required to raise and lower the water level. Workers had to excavate a tunnel -- a major engineering feat for its day -- so boats could travel between New Lisbon and Hanoverton. The canal was not completed until January of 1848 due to financial problems. The Middle division of the canal -- from Lockbridge (where the canal crossed State Route 172) to Kensington - was not well used because of questionable water supply and the danger of falling rocks in the tunnel at Hanoverton and was abandoned after 1852 although the Eastern and Western Divisions operated until 1854.

The chartering of the Cleveland & Pittsburgh Railroad on 11 March 1845 was to spell the end of the Canal Era in Ohio within a decade. The first train from Cleveland to Wellsville arrived on 4 March 1852 and train travel soon became very popular. Columbiana County

eventually had a railway link to the Mahoning Valley via the Youngstown & Suburban Railway. Real estate sales boomed along the new railways.

Concurrently the nation was edging toward a civil war. The early inhabitants of Salem and the surrounding area were members of the Society of Friends, or Quakers who were against slavery and for woman's rights. The 3<sup>rd</sup> Woman's Rights convention was held in Salem in 1850. The Quakers and other abolitionists created what came to be known as the "Underground Railroad", a system of "safe houses" stretching through the free states. Slaves traveled from safe house to safe house across Ohio towards Canada. Throughout the mid-1800's Salem was known as the headquarters for the Western Anti-Slavery Society and was the home to the national weekly paper called the *Anti-Slavery Bugle*. There are numerous accounts of "safe houses" in Lisbon, Salem and Hanoverton.

Columbiana County also has the distinction of being the northernmost point the Confederacy reached during the Civil War. Confederate General John Hunt Morgan crossed the Ohio River south of Wellsville with his troops on 26 July 1863 and engaged the Union forces. His forces lost the battle with 30 killed, 50 wounded and 200 taken prisoner. He and his men fled but were captured six hours later near West Point in Madison Township. A marker was erected on the spot where General Morgan and his 336 troops were captured.

More recently, Columbiana County was designated part of the federal Appalachian Region on 18 October 1990 by President George H. W. Bush. The County Board of Commissioners requested the designation in 1987 as a means of securing federal aid for economic development and infrastructure.

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Columbiana County is a rural county with scenic beauty, small to medium-sized farms, small towns. ....Columbiana County contains two hospitals with a total of \_\_\_\_ beds; Salem Community Hospital and East Liverpool City Hospital. There are four daily newspapers that serve the county as well as two radio stations. There are 12 school districts including the Columbiana County Career and Technical Center as well as two branch campuses of Kent State University and a private 4-year college. Recreational facilities include 17 museums, 2 state parks, 1 county park and 3 wildlife areas. There are numerous festivals, historical locations, and antique and craft stores. The Rogers Community Sale is a regional attraction with space for over 1,200 vendors at this unique weekly rural flea market.